accompanied Nott on his march across Afghanistan in August 1842, only to be horrified by the war crimes committed by British troops in Kabul and Istalif. He returned via the Khyber to India, but spent the rest of his career in Persia and the Arab world.

Sir Robert Sale (1782–1845): Sale was a veteran of the Company army known to his men as ‘Fighting Bob’ as he refused to stay at the back and always threw himself into the fiercest hand-to-hand fighting. Sale fought at the capture of Ghazni, and it was his violent punitive expeditions in Kohistan in 1840 that did much to unite the Tajiks in their opposition to the Anglo-Sadozai regime. At the end of October 1841 he was ordered back to India, punishing the Ghilzai for their resistance on the way out. As his force progressed down the Khord Kabul and Tezin passes they were caught in a series of well-executed ambushes and the expedition, which was supposed to chastise the tribesmen, ended by having a very different victim: in the narrow web of the mountain passes, the hunters found that they had now become the prey. With what remained of his force, Sale reached Jalalabad on 12 November. There his brigade remained under siege until finally breaking out and defeating Akbar Khan on 7 April 1842. They were relieved by Pollock’s Army of Retribution nine days later, and accompanied it to Kabul. On 18 September, Sale was reunited with his formidable wife, **Florentia, Lady Sale (1790–1853)**, who had survived the Retreat from Kabul and subsequently spent nine months as a hostage of Akbar Khan. ‘Fighting Bob’ was killed three years later during the Anglo-Sikh War of 1845. Lady Sale emigrated as a widow to South Africa and died in Cape Town in 1853.

Sir George Pollock (1786–1872): Pollock was a precise, ruthless and doggedly efficient Company general who had been in India more than thirty years when he received his orders to relieve the besieged British garrison in Jalalabad. His reputation had been built on careful planning and meticulous logistics, and he was determined not to be bullied into acting prematurely. After carefully collecting supplies in Peshawar, he forced the Khyber with his Army of Retribution, finally relieving Jalalabad on 16 April. After another pause to collect more transport and ammunition, he advanced, defeating Akbar Khan in the Tezin Pass and retaking Kabul on 16 September. After destroying Istalif, and burning much of Kabul, he